The Language of Scent

Midterm Design Proposal

01. Introduction

The Language of Scent is an interactive website concept that helps users understand fragrance classifications, scent notes, and sensory descriptions through visual exploration.

The project focuses on organizing complex and overlapping fragrance information into a clearer, more intuitive experience.

02. Concept & Problem

Fragrance is difficult to understand through written descriptions alone. Perfume descriptions often combine fragrance families, individual notes, and subjective expressions without clearly explaining their differences.

Terms such as floral, powdery, musky, and woody can refer to different aspects of scent, and unfamiliar combinations make it even harder to imagine how a fragrance might smell. The problem is not simply a lack of information, but how that information is described, classified, and connected.

03. Concept Development & Intended Experience

My initial idea was to create a visual fragrance discovery service where users could understand scents intuitively, identify their preferences, and find similar perfumes. While exploring existing services, I found that many already offered perfume searches and recommendations. However, understanding the fragrance information itself remained challenging.

I decided to focus first on helping users understand scent characteristics and relationships. This creates a foundation that could later support personalized discovery and recommendations.

I want users to get a clearer sense of what fragrance descriptions actually mean through colors, images, and textures, rather than relying on words alone. By exploring fragrance families, notes, and sensory descriptions, users can see how different scents are classified, how they overlap, and how they connect. Instead of presenting everything at once, the website allows users to explore these relationships gradually through interaction.

04. Taxonomy & Research

I researched different fragrance classification systems and found that they do not always use the same categories or terminology. For this project, I selected The Perfume Society’s eight-family framework: Fresh, Floral, Floriental, Ambrée, Gourmand, Chypre, Woody, and Fougère.

This provides a recognizable starting structure while acknowledging that fragrance classifications can overlap and vary between systems.

05. Classification Decisions

Organizing the fragrance information was one of the most challenging parts of the project. I separated three commonly mixed concepts: Family: The overall scent direction, Note: A recognizable scent impression, Descriptor: A word describing how a scent feels

I also considered materials, accords, and fragrance evolution. Rather than treating every concept as an equal category, I kept the main structure focused on three types and incorporated more technical information into relevant explanations.

Fragrance evolution was excluded to keep the experience focused on scent characteristics and relationships.

06. Information Architecture

Fragrance information is not organized into completely separate groups. The same note or descriptor can appear across multiple families.

For example, Vanilla can be associated with Gourmand, Ambrée, and Floriental, but its role can differ depending on the context. To represent this, I designed a shared relationship structure instead of duplicating concepts under each family.

This allows the interface to show both the overall classification and connections between categories.

07. Content & Data Model

I organized a curated dataset of eight families, 33 unique notes, and 24 descriptors, including 48 Family-Note and 40 Family-Descriptor connections.

Each family has a selection of representative notes and descriptors, while repeated concepts are stored as shared information.

The dataset is intended as an educational model rather than a complete or universally standardized classification.

The main challenge was deciding which relationships were useful to show and how to represent them without making the interface overwhelming.

08. References & Moodboard

My initial visual direction was Transparent Nude White + Experimental Beauty Editorial, combining nude skin tones, white and cream backgrounds, glass, water, ice, glossy textures, and surreal beauty imagery with a clean laboratory-like atmosphere.

The reference collection explores both visual styles and interface experiences, while the moodboard brings these elements together into one consistent direction.

https://www.behance.net/gallery/236881439/HoloConnect-Redefining-Interaction-in-Mixed-Reality?tracking_source=search_projects|Liquid+Glass+UI&l=103

https://www.behance.net/gallery/250254247/Liquid-Glass-Marketplace-UI-Exploration?tracking_source=search_projects|Liquid+Glass+UI&l=58

https://www.behance.net/gallery/253876155/Liquid-Glass-YouTube-Subscribe-Pack-Animated-UI?tracking_source=search_projects|Liquid+Glass+UI&l=96

https://www.behance.net/gallery/228530943/Liquid-Glass-Smart-Construction-Dashboard-UI?tracking_source=search_projects|Liquid+Glass+UI&l=41

09. Visual Language

I chose a neutral white and nude color palette to allow each fragrance family's colors and imagery to stand out without competing with the interface. The clean, laboratory-inspired structure also supports the project's goal of organizing complex scent information clearly.

Translating this atmosphere into UI elements was challenging, so I later drew inspiration from Liquid Glass design to express transparency, reflections, and visual depth. I refined the contrast and typography to keep the interface readable while maintaining the original Experimental Beauty Editorial direction.

10. Sitemap

The website is organized around three connected sections: Learn, Atlas, and Compare.

Learn introduces the basic concepts. Atlas allows users to explore fragrance families and their relationships with notes and descriptors. Compare provides a closer look at similar or easily confused scent impressions.

The comparison feature is integrated into the exploration process rather than presented as a separate main activity.

11. User Flow

I initially considered displaying multiple categories and connections at once, but this made the information too dense.

Instead, I chose progressive disclosure. Users begin with eight fragrance families and reveal related notes and descriptors by selecting a category.

Further selections provide explanations, images, and optional comparisons.

This approach maintains the larger structure while allowing users to focus on one relationship at a time.

12. Wireframes

The wireframes focus on two main layouts: Homepage with Learn and Atlas Overview.

The homepage uses a split layout with an introduction, a visual area, and a clear entry button. Below it, three cards introduce the basic concepts of Family, Note, and Descriptor.

The Atlas places eight fragrance families in the main exploration area, with a separate panel for explanations and related information.

These wireframes focus on information hierarchy, navigation, and spatial organization before applying the final visual design.

13. Design Preview

Each fragrance family uses a distinct, muted color to support visual recognition, while neutral backgrounds keep the information clear and organized.

I used editorial typography, subtle transparency, and restrained visual elements to balance sensory expression with readability. Interactive elements are designed to make available actions and selected information easy to recognize.

The result aims to make fragrance exploration feel intuitive and visually engaging without losing the clarity of the underlying classification system.

14. Sensory Detail & Comparison

Some fragrance descriptions can sound similar even when they refer to different sensory impressions. To address this, I designed a comparison feature that users can access while exploring a scent.

For example, users can compare Powdery and Soapy through descriptions, imagery, and visual representations of their characteristics.

I initially explored a five-axis radar chart to communicate these differences visually. However, because scent impressions are subjective, I am still considering how to present comparisons clearly without implying precise or scientifically measured values.

The goal is to help users recognize subtle differences and better understand unfamiliar fragrance descriptions.

15. Responsive Design & Interaction

On desktop, the fragrance map and its explanations appear side by side, allowing users to explore relationships while viewing related details.

On mobile, the content is reorganized into a more sequential layout, focusing on one selection at a time rather than simply shrinking the desktop interface. I also plan to use hover, focus, and transition effects to highlight interactive elements and clarify changes.

16. Reflection & Next Steps

This project began as an idea for visual fragrance discovery, personal scent preferences, and perfume recommendations. However, researching existing services led me to reconsider the problem. Before helping users find perfumes, I wanted to make fragrance information itself easier to understand.

The biggest challenge was organizing overlapping concepts and relationships into a clear visual structure. I explored different classification systems and ways to represent connections, then decided to separate concept types, preserve shared relationships, and reveal information gradually rather than displaying everything at once.

I also experimented with sensory imagery and comparison charts, but I am still refining how to communicate subjective impressions without making them appear objectively measurable.

The next step is to develop the proposed experience using HTML/CSS and improve the design through feedback and testing.

In the longer term, I would like to build on this foundation by connecting fragrance concepts to actual perfumes, helping users explore their preferences and discover fragrances with similar characteristics.